

The Challenge of Integration: A Review of the M&A Integration Literature

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The integration of acquired or merging firms is a key driver of the success or failure of mergers and acquisitions (M&As). Over the last 30 years, a substantial body of research has addressed M&A integration, offering rich but widely dispersed insights into this phenomenon. This paper takes stock of the current knowledge, based on a review of articles published in scholarly journals. The review advances the conceptual understanding of the phenomenon by inductively developing an overarching framework for the M&A integration literature, where integration success is a function of context, structural and communication-based interventions, which interact with collective sensemaking processes and negotiations among integration stakeholders. Based on this framework, a research agenda is suggested. I proposes that, in particular, the interaction between structural interventions and leadership warrants further study. Also, little is known about integration project management and integration team composition or the interaction between integration context and collective sensemaking processes. Finally, there is a shortage of research on temporal dynamics within integration projects. The review demonstrates that M&A scholars made substantial progress regarding our understanding of the M&A integration process, yet much remains to be done.

Introduction

Mergers and acquisitions (M&As) are one of the prime tools for firm growth (Bauer and Matzler 2014), but strategic and operational goals associated with M&A deals are often not met (Cartwright and Schoenberg 2006; Halebian *et al.* 2009; Tuch and O'Sullivan 2007). King *et al.* (2004) found that contingency conditions such as firm (dis-)similarities or deal characteristics explain only a small fraction of the observed variance in M&A outcomes. In 1986, Jemison and Sitkin published an influential article in the *Academy of Management Review*, complementing this traditional decision perspective with a process view, asking 'how should acquirers select and integrate a target' instead of 'under what (pre-) conditions should one buy a target' (Jemison and Sitkin 1986). Jemison and Sitkin conceptualized M&As as processes ranging from pre-deal screening to the conclusion of M&A integration some years after closing. This perspective forcefully put the topic of M&A

integration on the agenda of M&A scholars, and a substantial body of research strengthened the notion that, in particular, the integration stage is an important driver of M&A success (e.g. Angwin and Meadows 2015; Graebner 2004; Heimeriks *et al.* 2012; Larsson and Finkelstein 1999).

Research on M&A integration, encompassing both post-merger and post-acquisition integration,¹ developed in strength in the late 1980s and has attracted broad research interest ever since (Teerikangas *et al.* 2012). High-profile M&A failures attributed to poor integration management have kept interest in the phenomenon high. The merger of Daimler and Chrysler

¹Most research on post-merger and post-acquisition integration does not differentiate between mergers (of equals) and acquisitions, where one firm dominates the relationship. To account for this, we follow Schweiger and Goulet (2000) and apply the neutral term M&A integration. Distinctions between mergers and acquisitions are discussed in the discussion section.

in 1998 is an exemplary case where the pre-merger success of both companies turned into disaster in the integration stage (Monin *et al.* 2013). Underestimated social and cultural issues, incompatible management styles and questionable communication led to dissatisfaction and resistance at Chrysler, a sharp decline in performance and corresponding dissatisfaction at Daimler (Weber and Camerer 2003). Ultimately, Daimler sold Chrysler, with a direct financial loss of US\$37bn (Isidore 2007). Many of the issues that surfaced in the Daimler–Chrysler integration serve to illustrate how structural and social phenomena interact to affect M&A integration processes and outcomes.

In 2000, Schweiger and Goulet issued a call to develop a consistent understanding of the M&A integration phenomenon (Schweiger and Goulet 2000). Since then, we have seen a variety of reviews touching different aspects of M&A integration, but none has sufficiently addressed the concern that the field needs a comprehensive understanding of M&A integration. Reviews on M&A in general (e.g. Gomes *et al.* 2013; Tuch and O'Sullivan 2007) and specific sub-topics of M&A integration such as culture (Schoenberg 2000; Stahl and Voigt 2008), social identity (Ullrich and van Dick 2007), leadership (Junni and Sarala 2014), international acquisitions (Ghauri and Buckley 2003), or methodology (Cartwright *et al.* 2012; Meglio and Risberg 2011), were published, as well as reviews that do not develop a synthesizing framework (Teerikangas and Joseph 2012). Complementing and extending this previous work and taking up the call issued by Schweiger and Goulet (2000) 16 years ago, this paper presents a systematic review (Tranfield *et al.* 2003) of the scholarly literature on M&A integration, following three distinct aims: First, it suggest an overarching framework for M&A integration research, which is inductively developed. Such a framework is now as necessary as it was in 2000, maybe even more so, as the stock of knowledge has increased substantially over these past years and integrating the dispersed sub-themes into a consistent framework has become even more difficult (Teerikangas *et al.* 2012). Second, the review aims to provide a broad perspective on M&A integration research that links the heterogeneous sub-topics of the integration phenomenon and offers an overview of developments in the last 30 years. This approach complements specialized reviews and suggests a perspective on how the dispersed themes and topics interrelate. Third, this encompassing perspective helps to develop a concurrent research agenda, which can guide future work in the field. In doing so, the

following research synthesis takes the academic discussion on M&A integration one step further on the journey towards a comprehensive understanding of the M&A integration phenomenon.

Delineating M&A integration

To define the field of interest, this study follows Larsson and Finkelstein's delineation of M&A integration as 'the degree of interaction and coordination of the two firms involved in a merger or acquisition' (Larsson and Finkelstein 1999, p. 6). Merger and acquisition integration begins with the closure of an M&A deal and typically takes years to complete, with integration planning often beginning well before deal closure (Ellis *et al.* 2011; Ranft and Lord 2002; Schweiger and Goulet 2000). The integration of one firm into another has many facets, and the conditions driving success or failure are complex. To minimize this complexity and derive a blueprint for an appropriate integration strategy, a variety of models have been suggested to either categorize the integration attempts into a manageable number of integration archetypes or capture the key drivers of integration performance. The most influential of these categorization models is a 2×2 matrix with strategic interdependence and need for organizational autonomy as dimensions, resulting in the archetypical integration approaches of absorption (low need for autonomy, high strategic interdependence), preservation (high need for autonomy, low strategic interdependence) and symbiosis (high strategic interdependence, high need for autonomy) put forward by Haspeslagh and Jemison (1991). Various other categorizations have also been suggested (e.g. Ellis and Lamont 2004; Liu and Woywode 2013; Nahavandi and Malekzadeh 1988; Wei and Clegg 2014). Of the integrated models of key drivers of integration success, Larsson and Finkelstein's (1999) is the most influential. In this model, the combination potential of the acquisition influences synergy realization (high, if the synergy potential is high), organizational integration (deep integration, if the combination potential is high) and employee resistance (high, if the combination potential is high). Organizational integration increases employee resistance as well as synergy realization, while employee resistance relates negatively to synergy realization. Several contingencies (management style similarity, cross-border M&A, relative size) complement this approach. Bauer and Matzler (2014)

presented a comparable model, with strategic and cultural complementarity and degree and speed of integration as predictors of integration outcome. Angwin (2012) discussed those as well as a variety of other integration models, and the broad variety found suggests that no single model can account for the complexity of the integration process. Miczka and Größler (2010) put forward a more complex approach, integrating about 35 individual aspects into their conceptual model of different aspects relevant in an integration process, subsumed under the headings capability transfer, employee motivation, cultural change and integration management. The resulting display of causalities, feedback loops and contingencies is illustrative, but the level of complexity in such a model and the amount of information required for deriving predictions from it limit its usefulness in scholarly and practical terms. Angwin and Meadows (2015) concluded that the main weakness of the simpler models lies in their neglect of important processes and contingencies. Comprehensive models, however, reach a degree of complexity that impairs their usefulness. Because of this problem, a 'theory of integration' (Schweiger and Goulet 2000) has not been developed so far, and the vast majority of M&A integration research focuses on specific sub-topics, such as integration depth, leadership, cultural distance or experience. Those sub-topics are not well linked, however (Schweiger and Goulet 2000). In the following, an integrative framework is suggested based on a review of the literature. The goal of this framework is to foster understanding of how the variety of M&A integration sub-topics interrelates in shaping integration outcomes. This framework then serves to take stock of what we know and to identify important areas for future research.

Methodology

The following systematic literature review (Jones and Gatrell 2014; Tranfield *et al.* 2003) covers publications in academic journals on M&A integration published between 1986, the year of Jemison and Sitkin's seminal piece (Jemison and Sitkin 1986), and February 2016. The goal of this review is to synthesize the dispersed perspectives on M&A integration by means of a conceptual framework, without attempting to duplicate specialized reviews on sub-themes such as culture (e.g. Teerikangas and Very 2006) or methodology (e.g. Meglio and Risberg 2011).

Following established practice in management reviews (e.g. Miller *et al.* 2014; Strutzenberger

and Ambos 2014), coverage was restricted to peer-reviewed scholarly journals. Sample development began with a keyword search for 'post-merger integration' and 'post-acquisition integration' in EBSCO Business Source Complete, duplicated in Google Scholar to ensure comprehensiveness. Snowball sampling was also applied to identify additional articles. Also included was the *Advances in Mergers and Acquisitions* book series, which publishes journal-like academic articles on M&A topics. The search was conducted by the author and duplicated by a post-graduate research assistant, while another senior scholar contributed complementary sources where necessary (see Greenhalgh and Peacock 2005, on sampling for literature reviews).

This search procedure led to a sample of 480 studies. From those, pieces were selected in which M&A integration was the focus of the empirical or conceptual work, excluding work on topics such as target selection, pre-deal negotiations and general M&A performance. Empirical as well as conceptual papers (i.e. theory-development papers without an empirical part) were allowed in the final sample, but research synthesis papers (reviews and meta-analyses) were deselected to obtain the focus on primary contributions. This selection algorithm resulted in a final sample of 193 studies. Those papers were all read carefully, building an extensive Excel file that helped in organizing the data. I took notes on topics and relations between topics, and extracted the key messages of the papers. Iteratively, appropriate topic headings emerged and, in later stages of this iteration process, links between those topics became clear. In that way, the framework presented below was inductively built and constantly modified by iteration between sample and model (Tranfield *et al.* 2003). This process was consistently discussed with another senior researcher from the field. Insightful comments obtained in the review process further helped to refine the framework.

The final sample covers 193 contributions from 86 different outlets, indicating the heterogeneity typical for M&A integration research (Table 1). The most frequent outlets for integration research are the well-established strategy and general management journals such as *Academy of Management Journal*, *Strategic Management Journal* and *British Journal of Management*. Regarding empirical focus, about two-thirds of the studies in the sample examine the firm level, and one-third focus on employees in M&A integration processes. There is no apparent focus on a particular industry, but a clear regional focus on the US

Table 1. Sampled journals

Journal	N	Journal	N	Journal	N	Journal	N
Academy of Management J	9	HR Development Internat	1	J of Business Research	2	Leadership & Organizational Development J	1
Academy of Management Perspectives	1	Human Relations	1	J of Business Strategy	1	Leadership Quarterly	3
Academy of Management Review	2	Human Resource Management	1	J of Business Studies Quarterly	1	Long Range Planning	6
Administrative Science Quarterly	3	Human Resource Management J	3	J of Business Venturing	1	Management Communication Quarterly	1
Advances in Developing Human Resources	1	Industrial Management & Data Systems	1	J of Financial Services Research	1	Management Decision	2
Advances in Mergers and Acquisitions	17	Industrial Marketing Management	3	J of Health Organization and Management	1	Management International J	2
Asian Business and Management	1	Industry & Innovation	1	J of Information Technology Theory and Application	1	Management Science	1
Baltic J of Management	1	Information Systems J	1	J of Internat Business Studies	1	Organization Science	9
British J of Management	8	Internat Business Review	4	J of Internat Management	2	Organization Studies	7
British J of Social Psychology	1	Internat J of Conflict Management	1	J of Leadership and Organization Studies	1	Organizational Dynamics	1
Business & Society	1	Internat J of Human Resource Management	4	J of Management	3	Pharmaceuticals Policy	1
Corporate Reputation Review	1	Internat J of Information Management	1	J of Management Science	1	Problems and Perspectives in Management	1
Cross Cultural Management: An Intern J	1	Internat J of Intercultural Relations	1	J of Management Studies	9	R&D Management	1
Economics of Innov & New Venture Performance	1	Internat J of Manpower	1	J of Managerial Development	1	Research Policy	3
Emergence: Complex & Org	1	Internat J of Project Management	1	J of Managerial Psychology	2	Scandinavian J of Management	3
Employee Relations	2	Internat J of Traing&Dev	1	J of Marketing	1	Scientometrics	1
Enterprise Information Systems	1	Internat J of Value-Based Management	1	J of Organizational Change Management	4	Service Industries J	1
European Economic Review	1	Internat Review of Finance	1	J of Social and Development Sciences	1	Strategic Change	2
European J of Work & Organizational Psychology	1	J of Applied Behavioral Science	2	J of Strategic Information Systems	1	Strategic Management J	14
European J of Work and Organizational Psychology	1	J of Applied Communication Research	1	J of World Business	2	Thunderbird Intern Business Review	1
European Management J	4	J of Business and Social Science	1	Kybernetes	1		
Harvard Business Review	1	J of Business Ethics	1	Leadership	1		

and Western Europe. Interestingly, qualitative and quantitative methods were found with almost the same frequency. This is discussed towards the end of the paper.

Findings

Integrating framework

The goal of the following review is to identify key themes in M&A integration research, for which important insights are highlighted, and to condense these insights into a coherent framework. Building on iterations between data and model, I suggest the framework shown in Figure 1.

The inductive analysis revealed four groups of topics that independently and conjointly affect integration outcomes. Merger and acquisition integration is a dynamic change process; interactions between conditions and interventions are therefore critical to understand M&A outcomes. The context of an integration project constitutes background conditions as they stand before the integration begins and has a direct bearing on what is achievable during M&A integration, as well as the main opportunities and challenges that will probably arise (arrow 1). Cultural distance, based on heterogeneous national or organizational cultures, for example, is likely to provide challenges, while internal relatedness opens opportunities for cost synergy realization. Context also describes pre-deal stakeholder power relations or the relative status of the integrating firms, which affects collective sensemaking and negotiations (arrow 2). Structural interventions are management decisions on structures, processes and systems that set the frame for the integration. Those need to fit the context (arrow 3). Internal relatedness, for example, calls for deep integration to exploit cost synergies, which in turn suggests fast integration to minimize the period of uncertainty for employees. Leadership and communication-based intervention covers the interventions of managers to influence the relationship between context and outcomes (arrow 4), e.g. acculturation management. In addition, leadership and communication-based interventions also moderate the relationship between context and structural interventions, e.g. through sensegiving activities that help improve the fit between structural interventions and context (arrow 5). The collective sensemaking and negotiations perspective implies that employee sensemaking and negotiations between internal stakeholders affect what the management can and will do in an integration project,

while structural and leadership-based interventions in turn affect sensemaking and negotiation processes. The motivation of internal stakeholders to engage in the integration process, for example, influences which structural (arrow 6) and communication-based interventions (arrow 7) the management can or will engage in, while managerial sensegiving activities or structural decisions affect employee sensemaking and intra-organizational negotiations. Structural interventions, leadership and communication-based interventions as well as collective sensemaking and negotiations are part of the dynamic process that unfolds over the course of the integration. This implies that the framework carries a strong temporal dimension, to which this paper returns below. In the following, I discuss each of the topics in more detail.

Context

In M&A integration, context refers to the contingencies of an integration. Context relates to attributes of the firms involved (e.g. integration experience, firm strategy, employee predisposition) and to the relationship between the firms' attributes (e.g. relatedness, relative pre-acquisition performance, cultural distance).

Internal and external relatedness. Internal and external relatedness, which is the complementarity of resources and processes of acquirer and target, is an important driver of integration success (Bauer and Matzler 2014; Kim and Finkelstein 2009; Marco and Rauser 2011; Very *et al.* 1997). A good fit between acquirer and target ensures value creation and/or value appropriation potential through a fruitful recombination of resources, as well as smooth integration processes (Larsson and Finkelstein 1999). The link between strategic and organizational fit and M&A performance has been widely examined in other fields of M&A research, particularly the finance perspective, and has been the subject of various reviews (Haleblian *et al.* 2009; Tuch and O'Sullivan 2007). Some studies have focused on the effects of different dimensions of relatedness on M&A integration, which I address in the following.

Relatedness in the formal organization has little bearing on integration performance, as the formal organization can be changed relatively easily (Datta 1991). Relatedness (i.e. overlap) in functions provides the potential for cost synergies; however, realizing these synergies increases employee resistance, as cost synergies of this type typically imply job cuts

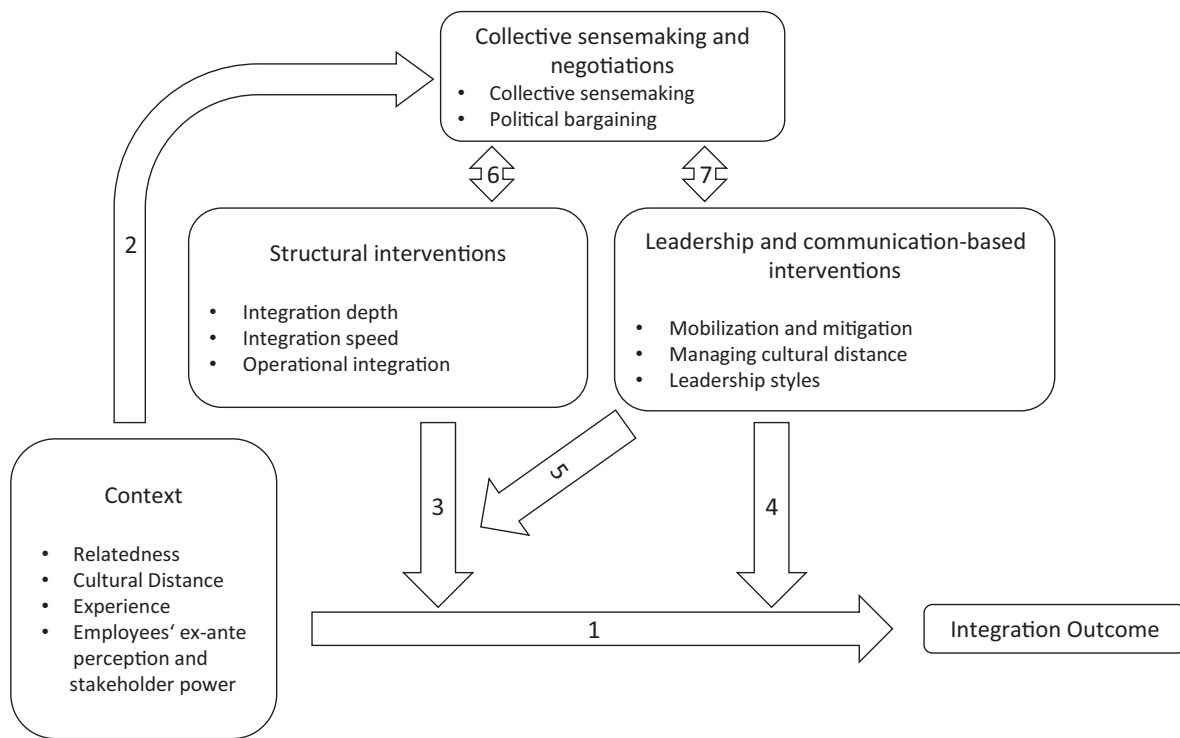


Figure 1. Framework of M&A integration research

(Conyon *et al.* 2002; Larsson and Finkelstein 1999). Ranft and Lord (2002) found that differences in size and performance limit communication between the firms involved in an integration, increase the autonomy of the smaller firm and improve employee retention. Regarding market relatedness, overlaps between the firms involved seem to benefit integration success (Ellis *et al.* 2009), contingent upon the asset management strategy applied (Daniliuc *et al.* 2014), as well as the degree to which the firms depend on each other (Mtar 2010). A pre-deal alliance between acquirer and target is only positive when the target is loosely integrated. The reason is false learning: the insights that managers derive from alliance events are falsely transferred to M&A integration, which follows different rules (Zollo and Reuer 2010).

For research and development (R&D)-related acquisitions, the degree of relatedness of the knowledge stocks of the integrating firms is important (Makri *et al.* 2010). The relationship between such an overlap and post-integration R&D productivity seems to follow an inverted U-shape (Cloudt *et al.* 2006; Valentini and Dawson 2010). Too strong an overlap provides little opportunity for learning (Cassiman *et al.* 2005); too little overlap means that the firms lack the absorptive capacity necessary to put the knowledge of the

respective other firm to productive use (Cohen and Levinthal 1994; Desyllas and Hughes 2010; Lin and Jang 2010). The relevance of this effect for integration performance depends on the R&D strategy of the acquirer. If an acquired firm is bought to supplement the R&D efforts of the acquiring firm, overlap is important. If there is no such intention, knowledge relatedness is not critical (Ruckman 2008). It is generally beneficial for R&D-related acquisitions if the knowledge base of the acquirer is not too focused, providing more options for collaboration (Desyllas and Hughes 2010), and if the acquirer commits strongly to R&D himself (Tsai and Wang 2008).

Cultural distance. Cultural differences can be caused by heterogeneous national or organizational cultures. Different national cultures imply structural and mental differences (Liu and Dong 2007; Yildiz 2016) and complicated communication (Cheng and Seeger 2012; Nahavandi and Malekzadeh 1988; Pucik 2008; Reus 2012; Shrivastava 1986). Accordingly, differences in the national cultures of the firms involved in an integration process possibly hamper integration performance (Bauer *et al.* 2016) in M&A integration. However, national culture distance also

offers learning opportunities (Ellis *et al.* 2011) and increases willingness to accept differing organizational cultures (Very *et al.* 1997). Lee *et al.* (2015) suggest that differing national cultures will often cause tensions in the early stages of an integration, but can create learning opportunities, provided that they are managed well. The national cultural background also affects how acquirers approach integration projects (Faulkner *et al.* 2003).

Regarding distance between organizational cultures, Nahavandi and Malekzadeh (1988) suggested a 2×2 matrix to predict how the cultures are likely to relate. The two dimensions are (a) the tendency towards cultural preservation and (b) the attractiveness of the acquirer and the target. Strong preservation tendencies and low attractiveness of the partner lead to cultural separation. High attractiveness and low tendency to preserve the old culture result in eagerness for cultural assimilation. If both dimensions rank highly, the acquired firm's culture will become a sub-culture of the acquiring firm. If both dimensions rank low, the result will be de-culturation, where integrating employees lose their previous organizational culture without adopting a new one. Acculturation stress develops if the preferred modes of acculturation of the integrating firms are dissimilar (Nahavandi and Malekzadeh 1988; cf. also Yildiz 2014). The link between acculturation and partner attractiveness has been empirically supported (Sarala 2010; Very *et al.* 1997). The negative effects of cultural distance are particularly pronounced in cases of deep integration (Bauer *et al.* 2014; Jöns *et al.* 2007; Slangen 2006) and are contingent upon differences in the cultures of the involved organizations (Weber *et al.* 2009).

While research has found that differences in national culture can affect the integration positively as well as negatively, differences between the organizational cultures are often harmful (Cheng and Seeger 2012; Froese and Goeritz 2007; Pepper and Larson 2006; Vaara 2000; Vaara *et al.* 2012). Similarity in management style, for example, is an important predictor of integration success, as different management styles cause problems for collaboration and complicate the realization of synergies (Datta 1991; Larsson and Finkelstein 1999). Correspondingly, Bauer and Matzler (2014) found that cultural similarity provides a common ground, which reduces the need for formal integration (cf. Puranam *et al.* 2009). One problem when considering cultural differences is that it is often not possible to assess fully the degree of cultural relatedness before the integration begins (Greenwood

et al. 1994). Therefore, it falls to within-integration leadership to develop solutions to mitigate acculturation problems.

Prior integration experience. Intuition suggests that firms that have integrated targets in the past should do better in future integrations than firms without integration experience. This relationship has been backed by some evidence (Al-Laham *et al.* 2010; Barkema and Schijven 2008; Duncan and Mtar 2006; Ellis *et al.* 2009), but findings are inconclusive (Gerpott 1995; Haleblan and Finkelstein 1999; Zollo 2009). Experience is, as a general rule, more important for deep integrations than for loose ones (Colombo *et al.* 2007; Puranam and Srikanth 2007). Ellis *et al.* (2011) found evidence that learning occurs only between integrations with comparable characteristics regarding size, geographic focus or product portfolio. Strengthening this notion, Hébert and colleagues found that lack of experience in a focal regional market diminishes subsidiary survival after an acquisition because of culturally inexperienced expatriates (Hébert *et al.* 2005). The complexities inherent in the integration process might even lead to a negative learning curve. If the number of previous integration events is not large, generalization from one integration event to another is difficult and often misleading (Haleblan and Finkelstein 1999), an effect Zollo (2009, p. 894) termed 'superstitious learning'. With a growing number of completed integration projects, firms are more likely to trust their experience. Yet, owing to causal ambiguity, conclusions that are drawn based on prior experience are often false. These two effects create a negative learning curve (Zollo 2009), where more experience actually decreases integration performance. The causal attribution of success or failure is also subject to outcome bias, leading decision-makers to interpret past events as overly positive if the overall outcome was positive and overly negative in the case of negative results (Vaara 2002).

Various conditions can help leverage pre-acquisition experience in a positive way. In particular, high-level management attention and careful and thorough integration planning help avoid negative learning curves (Yu *et al.* 2005; Zollo and Reuer 2010). Codification of integration experience (e.g. in the form of integration handbooks) also increases the chance of successful learning, provided that higher-order routines are in place that allow an acquirer to distinguish between integration cases where previously acquired experience applies from cases that require a different approach (Zollo and Singh 2004).

Heimeriks *et al.* (2012) found risk-management practices to be such a higher-order routine.

Employees' ex ante perception of the integration process and stakeholder power. An ideal employee in an integration project would act as corporate entrepreneur, motivated and able to develop the combining organizations along the lines of the integration plan (Thomson and McNamara 2001). However, in integration projects, employees experience job insecurity, process changes and cultural clashes (Choi *et al.* 2012; Hubbard and Purcell 2001; Joshi and Goyal 2013). Integrations thus often trigger negative emotional responses (Kiefer 2002; Kusstatscher 2006) and negatively affect the physical and psychological health of the employees involved (Makri and Antoniou 2012). It is thus not surprising that employees often enter integration processes with a sceptical attitude, although this is not always the case (Greenwood *et al.* 1994).

Bourantes and Nicandrou (1998) suggested a 2×2 matrix to model employee reactions to acquisition events, based on how active/passive and resistive/supportive employees are towards the integration process. The position that an employee has in this matrix depends, among other things, on his or her trust in the management and expectations of what effect the change will have on him or her (see also Lin and Wei 2006). The role a person has in the integration process also affects his or her stance towards the integration (Bijlsma-Frankema 2004; Brannen and Peterson 2009), as does pre-acquisition identification, i.e. the degree to which employees experience social identity with the employing firm (Colman and Lunnan 2011; Kroon *et al.* 2009; Ullrich and van Dick 2007). The perception of change as an opportunity or threat is a personality trait (Nikandrou *et al.* 2000) that may or may not translate into actual resistance, depending on group-level or organizational-level circumstances, such as trust in the management or incentives aligned with the change (Oreg 2006). The stance an individual takes towards change is influenced by interactions with others, i.e. it is socially constructed (Brannen and Peterson 2009; Vaara 2003), and can thus be influenced by leadership actions, which is discussed below.

Ex ante perceptions of the integration project also affect how easily key employees, those who possess knowledge and capabilities critical for the integration and subsequent value creation, can be retained (Angwin and Meadows 2009; Cording *et al.* 2008; Ellis *et al.* 2011; Graebner 2004; Ranft and Lord

2002). To retain key employees, status and appreciation, clearly outlined future career paths and incentive systems are crucial (Cannella and Hambrick 1993; Ranft and Lord 2002). In international mergers, the corporate language is also important, because it signals the dominance of one firm over the other and affects career paths as well as perceptions of identity and job security (Kroon *et al.* 2015; Piekkari *et al.* 2005; Vaara 2003). Stakeholder resistance is particularly relevant if the stakeholder is in a position of power from which he or she can actively affect the integration process (Clark *et al.* 2010; Monin *et al.* 2013). Employees, but also external stakeholders such as regulatory bodies, are often powerful forces in integration projects (Clark and Geppert 2011).

Structural interventions

The effect of context on integration performance depends on the setup of structures, processes and systems, which also influences and depends on how employees and other internal and external stakeholders experience the integration.

Integration depth. Choosing the depth of integration and the level of autonomy that an acquired firm retains is a core strategic decision in integration projects. Greater autonomy usually leads to higher motivation on the side of the acquired firm's employees (Datta and Grant 1990) and preserves the opportunity for independent thinking (Graebner 2004; Puranam *et al.* 2009), which is particularly important for knowledge-driven acquisitions (Ranft 2006; Ranft and Lord 2002). Deep integration increases an acquirer's ability to control the target and transfer routines (Pablo *et al.* 1996; Puranam *et al.* 2009) and resources (Ranft and Lord 2002), yet Reus *et al.* (2015) note that capability transfer from acquirer to target, often in the form of imposed management knowledge and a transfer of operational routines, can affect integration performance negatively. This relationship seems to be particularly pronounced in cases with deep functional integration, while strategic control remedies it to some degree. Tight integration might imply a loss in customer loyalty and market share (Homburg and Bucerius 2006; Kato and Schoenberg 2014) and, in general, decrease employee retention (Angwin 2004b; Angwin and Meadows 2009; Very *et al.* 1997). The costs associated with the integration process itself increase with the depth of integration (Slangen and Hennart 2008).

A benefit of deep integration is that it limits value appropriation by the target firm's stakeholders (Meyer 2008). For acquisitions of distressed targets, Castrogiovanni and Bruton (2000) found deep integration preferable to capital infusion and cost and asset cuts, as deep integration allows the acquiring firm to salvage the healthy parts of a distressed target. Angwin and Meadows (2015, p. 247) termed this type of integration 'intensive care'. However, deep integration might disrupt both firms because it is often necessary to change routines or structures in both firms to exploit fully the benefits of deep integration (Baroncelli 1998). Acquiring firms will often be reluctant to accept these disturbances, especially if the acquired firm is relatively small (Karim 2006). In this case, purchased firms tend to be systematically under-integrated (Barkema and Schijven 2008).

Overall, although some studies found deep integration to be generally beneficial for post-integration performance (Colombo *et al.* 2007), well-established contingencies are at work, particularly regarding the strategic rationale of the deal. When firms seek to realize cost synergies and align processes and procedures, deep integration yields beneficial results (Capron 1999; Homburg and Bucerius 2005; Puranam *et al.* 2009; Schoenberg and Bowman 2010), whereas acquisitions focusing on growth or knowledge have less need for deep integration (Schoenberg and Bowman 2010; Schweiger and Very 2003). In addition, the appropriate integration depth also depends on the relatedness of the focal firms (cf. the discussion on relatedness presented above). High similarity and high complementarity both favour deep integration (Bauer and Matzler 2014; Datta and Grant 1990; Zaheer *et al.* 2013). The specific knowledge of an acquired firm's managers can often help to mitigate the problems of deep integration and decrease the required integration depth (Graebner 2004).

Regarding R&D, deep integration is often associated with exploitation of the knowledge stock purchased in an acquisition (knowledge leverage), while loose integration implies exploratory R&D approaches (capability leverage; Gammelgaard 2005; Puranam and Srikanth 2007; Puranam *et al.* 2006). Deep integration binds resources, which might hamper innovation adaptation (Barden 2012; Cefis 2010). The productivity of R&D personnel usually falls sharply, and the retention of R&D personnel is difficult if an R&D department experiences loss of autonomy (Paruchuri and Eisenman 2012; Ranft and Lord 2002); but this effect diminishes with time (Puranam *et al.* 2006). The negative effect of integration depth

on R&D personnel is moderated by the loss of status an employee perceives due to the integration as well as his or her loss of network centrality (Paruchuri *et al.* 2006).

Firms can differentiate their approach to integration depth both operationally and symbolically (Angwin and Meadows 2015; Haspeslagh and Jemison 1991; Ranft and Lord 2002). Many authors have recommended fully integrating operational support functions such as information technology (IT), as those do not create competitive advantages when left alone, and considering independence for other functions (Alaranta and Kautz 2012; Hough *et al.* 2007; Merali and McKiernan 1993). Retaining a symbolic form of independence (e.g. retaining an acquired firm's name or logo) is also often helpful (Monin *et al.* 2013; Ranft and Lord 2002). Staffing of the post-deal top management is particularly important in both operational and symbolic terms (Ranft and Lord 2002).

Integration speed. Integration processes are major change events that can take years to complete (Shim 2011). The length of the process depends, in particular, on integration depth, pre-acquisition familiarity and strategic complementarity (Al-Laham *et al.* 2010; Angwin 2004b; Bauer and Matzler 2014; Schweizer 2005). However, setting the pace for the integration is, to some degree, also a management decision. High integration speed implies a shorter period of uncertainty for external (Homburg and Bucerius 2005 2006; Uzelac *et al.* 2015) and internal stakeholders (Colombo *et al.* 2007; Cording *et al.* 2008; Nikandrou *et al.* 2000). Fast completion of the integration process leads to quicker realization of benefits associated with the M&A deal (Epstein 2004). If a deal implies cuts in the workforce, it is often better to execute those cuts quickly before resistance escalates (Cording *et al.* 2008). Fast integration might also be preferable because the momentum of the early integration stage tends to get lost when the attention of management and employees turns elsewhere (Angwin 2004a). Slow integration, on the other hand, is less demanding for employees and integration management, as less needs to be done in a given period of time (Homburg and Bucerius 2006). Slower integration processes allow more attentive communication and help avoid disturbances caused by abrupt changes of organizational identity (Lee *et al.* 2014) as well as the deterioration of knowledge bases (Yoo *et al.* 2007). Slower integration speed also allows more time for trust building and sensegiving (Ranft and Lord 2002).

If a deal is difficult with regard to cultural distance or employee retention, slow integration may be preferable (Monin *et al.* 2013; Ranft and Lord 2002).

Operational integration. Shrivastava (1986) defined three general tasks for operational integration: procedural tasks, such as the alignment of accounting systems; physical tasks, such as resource allocation; and managerial and sociocultural tasks, such as the design of reward systems or the definition of roles. These hands-on integration tasks are often conducted by work groups headed by an integration manager (Ashkenas *et al.* 1998; Schweizer 2002; Teerikangas *et al.* 2011). These integration managers receive operational goals for the integration from the top management (e.g. regarding synergies to be achieved) and then conduct the operational steps required to reach these goals. Integration teams can include employees of the acquiring firm, the acquired firm and/or external consultants. Mixed teams signal that the acquiring firm cares about the target firm's interests, but those teams tend to suffer from more complicated decision-making (Ellis *et al.* 2009; Piske 2002).

Angwin and Urs (2014) explored how routines can be transferred in operational integration and found two strategies, which they termed 'combination' and 'superimposition'. They found that both strategies have positive and negative effects, contingent upon the stability of the respective routine and the stakeholder group affected. Frequent communication between employees of the involved firms is often required to integrate successfully on the operational level (Lauser 2010; Mitleton-Kelly 2006; Papadakis 2005; Ranft and Lord 2002) and is, in general, a key success factor in M&A integration (Larsson and Finkelstein 1999). Employees, however, tend to retain pre-integration communication patterns, a behaviour that Briscoe and Tsai (2012) termed 'relational inertia'. Over the integration process, intensity of communication between integrating firms often follows an inverted U-shape, starting slowly, peaking when routines change and decreasing when new routines are established (Allatta and Singh 2011). Various structural interventions have been suggested to foster communication between the firms involved. Working procedures that require interaction as well as face-to-face meetings and network building are of particular importance to intensifying communication (Chen *et al.* 2010; Moffat and McLean 2010; Ranft 2006; Ranft and Lord 2002). The downside of intense employee communication with the partnering firm is that it binds resources that cannot be committed

to other purposes. Briscoe and Tsai (2012) found that employees of an acquiring firm who interacted frequently with employees from the target firm had fewer resources available to help their co-workers at the acquiring firm. Communication intensity can also be contingent upon the workload of those involved in the integration, leading to situations where everyday work must take precedence over integration work (Greenwood *et al.* 1994).

Leadership and communication-based interventions

Leadership and communication-based interventions, the ongoing management of the 'human' side of an integration (Birkinshaw *et al.* 2000), concern the motivation of stakeholders and the mediation of problems triggered by context or structural interventions. It also refers to the management of stakeholders' interpretation of an ongoing integration process through sensegiving activities, regarding both internal and external stakeholders (cf. Junni and Sarala 2014 for a specialized review). Note that not only the top management, but also integration managers (Teerikangas *et al.* 2011), middle managers (Meyer 2006) and, to a lesser degree, human resources (HR) managers (Antila 2006; Tanure and Gonzales-Duarte 2007) have leadership responsibilities in M&A integrations.

Mobilization and mitigation. Leaders communicate with and lead internal and external stakeholders to set the pace for the integration (mobilization) and smooth the integration process (mitigation; Graebner 2004; Schuler and Jackson 2001). To mobilize, leaders steer the integration towards a preferred outcome through sensegiving, goal setting and identity building. Sensegiving involves attempts to develop and influence the collective interpretation of ongoing change, which is a powerful tool for reducing resistance towards change (Monin *et al.* 2013; Riad 2005). Goal setting is another important leadership tool, particularly because integration processes involve extended periods of uncertainty and ambiguity (Graebner 2004; Haspeslagh and Jemison 1991). Intermediate goals are a way to provide guidance along the way (Cording *et al.* 2008).

Integration processes also often imply changes in organizational identity that can affect employees' perception of the integration process (Dick *et al.* 2006; Olie 1994; Shanley and Correa 1992). A new organizational identity is the result of social construction processes as well as leadership interventions (Barmeyer and Mayrhofer 2008; Drori *et al.* 2013; Langley *et al.* 2012; Vieru and Rivard 2014).

Identity work in the wake of an integration can take very different forms, leading employees to active or passive, aggressive or accepting stances, affecting integration outcomes positively or negatively (Colman and Lunnan 2011; Langley *et al.* 2012). Elstak *et al.* (2015) found that the integration motive, in particular, affects post-integration identification with the employing business unit and that the perceived attractiveness of the integrating organization and business unit plays an important role when building identification. Leaders who were employed at the acquired firm prior to an acquisition are better suited to steer those identification processes than external leaders (Angwin 2004b). Transitional identities, preliminary ideas of what the final identity of the integrated entity will be, are helpful for simplifying the identification process (Clark *et al.* 2010; Lupina-Wegener *et al.* 2015). Providing a sense of continuity is also relevant (Lupina-Wegener *et al.* 2014). Finally, perceptions of success or failure also affect identity construction (Bligh 2006; Pepper and Larson 2006; Vaara 2002). This is one reason why early successes are important (Rouziez and Colman 2012). Still, a homogeneous identity is not a necessary outcome of an integration project, as pre-integration identities might survive and interact with the intended new identity, leading to identity plurality within the integrated organization (Bernardis and Giustiniano 2015; van Marrewijk 2016).

Mitigation involves leadership actions that attempt to reduce the negative responses of employees in integration processes (Graebner 2004). Effective leadership in this respect implies the management of employees' expectations through open communication and the creation of a perception of fairness (Choi *et al.* 2012; Hubbard and Purcell 2001; Kavanagh and Ashkanasy 2006; Maire and Colletette 2011; Meyer 2006; Ranft and Lord 2002). Ongoing integration projects frequently imply a breach of the informal contract between a firm and its employees at some time, which often leads to demotivation and resistance and might affect health and psychological well-being, particularly of those employed at the lower-status firm (Maguire and Phillips 2008; Makri and Antoniou 2012; Shleifer and Summers 1988; cf. also Yildiz 2016). Impressions of justice and fairness are important to avoid these negative effects (Ellis *et al.* 2009; Hubbard and Purcell 2001; Maguire and Phillips 2008; Searle and Ball 2004). Colquitt *et al.* (2013) distinguished between informational justice (open information flows and explanations of decisions made), procedural justice (participatory

decision-making and a chance for the affected employees to control procedures and processes) and distributional justice (equal or balanced distribution of resources, positions, benefits and burdens). In integration projects, informational justice requires frequent, planned and, in particular, honest communication (Cording *et al.* 2014; Ellis *et al.* 2009; Froese and Goeritz 2007; Piske 2002; Schweiger and DeNisi 1991; Searle and Ball 2004). Distributional justice refers to equality between the involved firms, but is a double-edged sword. For example, equality in staffing can create dissatisfaction and decision paralysis if positions are not staffed on the basis of candidates' competence (Meyer 2001; Meyer and Altenborg 2007). In a case study, Monin *et al.* (2013) found that the relevance of the different aspects of justice changed as the integration proceeded. Equality was an important concern immediately after deal closure while, in later stages, procedural justice dominated (cf. Lipponen *et al.* 2004). Communication in the form of sensegiving, sense-breaking and sense-hiding are tools that leaders can employ to influence perceptions of justice (Monin *et al.* 2013).

Although the importance of perceived justice is widely accepted, some authors have discussed boundary conditions. Edwards and Edwards (2012) found that considerations of justice are important under conditions of substantial change only. They also found little importance of procedural justice considerations when the acquirer and target were perceived to be similar, a finding at odds with the results obtained by Lipponen *et al.* (2004). Other authors have argued that informational justice, in particular, is no substitute for job security or other tangible outcomes (Lin and Wei 2006; Nikandrou *et al.* 2000; Piske 2002; Searle and Ball 2004).

Although it is clear that communication is a cornerstone of leadership regarding mitigation of negative perceptions (Graebner 2004), research currently focuses to a large degree on communication between management and employees, while the topic of communication with external stakeholders is surprisingly underdeveloped. Homburg and Bucerius (2005) reported that customer orientation of leadership personnel during M&A integration has the potential to limit the adverse effects of an integration event on customer retention. Öberg *et al.* (2007) suggested that, although managers often focus on customers as relevant stakeholders, actual integration work often does not accommodate this perspective. Kato and Schoenberg (2014) presented a case study on an integration from a customer perspective and found that overly

raising customer expectations before and during an integration aggravated the problems customers perceived. These findings clearly highlight that mitigating the integration's adverse effects on stakeholder groups beyond employees should be considered part of the leadership responsibilities in integration projects.

Managing cultural distance. The management of cultural issues, with a focus on heterogeneous organizational cultures, is a cornerstone of the integration literature, covered by various specialized reviews (Rottig *et al.* 2013; Schoenberg 2000; Stahl and Voigt 2005 2008; Teerikangas and Very 2006). Managing the acculturation process is particularly important in the case of large cultural differences (Barmeyer and Mayrhofer 2008; Choi *et al.* 2012; Olie 1994) and strong hierarchies (Barmeyer and Mayrhofer 2008; Froese and Goeritz 2007), but the possibilities for managers to do so are limited (Quah and Young 2005; Riad 2007). The process of acculturation, caused by heterogeneous organizational or national cultures, requires substantive change in values, beliefs and attitudes as well as in the social identity of the employees involved, possibly resulting in acculturative stress, difficult communication and collaboration, low employee retention, resistance to change and other frictions (Frantz 2012; Larsson and Lubatkin 2001; Lupina-Wegener 2013; Nahavandi and Malekzadeh 1988). A thorough culture assessment at the beginning of the acculturation process helps (Weber and Tarba 2012), as do mixed teams, the encouragement of socialization among employees ('get-togethers'), specialized integration teams, personnel exchange and detailed integration plans (Larsson and Lubatkin 2001; Lodorfo and Boateng 2006; Saunders *et al.* 2009). Employees can be trained to deal with cultural issues (Brannen and Peterson 2009) and cultural integration can be selective, integrating only specific aspects of an organizational culture (Weber *et al.* 1995). Schweiger and Goulet (2005) presented a quasi-experimental study where groups of employees received deep-level cultural training (cultural awareness training, cultural introspection, intense communication with employees belonging to the other culture), surface-level cultural training (limited dialog, no introspection) or no cultural training. In the group that received deep-level intercultural training, an increase in communication, perceived cultural understanding and cooperation occurred. Surface-level cultural training increased cultural understanding, but had no impact on cooperation. Experience with diversity

management (Bellinger and Hillman 2000) as well as multiculturalism (Reus 2012, referring to national cultures) also affects a firm's ability to handle cultural differences. It is currently not clear whether loose integration reduces the challenges associated with acculturation. Some authors have found such a relationship (Duncan and Mtar 2006), while others have not (Larsson and Lubatkin 2001; Vaara *et al.* 2012).

Leadership styles. Some research has examined which leadership styles are most successful in integrations. Choi and colleagues found that an appreciating leadership style is beneficial for integration performance (Choi *et al.* 2012; cf. also Schweizer and Patzelt 2012). Others have suggested that neo-charismatic and transformational leaders are most effective (Covin *et al.* 1997; Nemanich and Keller 2007; Nemanich and Vera 2009; Tikhomirov and Spangler 2010; Waldman and Javidan 2009). Dagnino and Pisano (2008) put forward the notion of 'acquisition champions' to describe how leaders affect integration processes through personality, behaviour and leadership tactics, while Zhang *et al.* (2015) discuss how leaders applying different leadership styles approach talent retention in integrations differently.

Collective sensemaking and negotiations

Many papers on M&A integration assume that the (acquiring) firm's management steers the integration process. Some authors have challenged this assumption. Managers are subject to pressure from external and internal stakeholders, resulting in the need to engage in micro-politics (Rees and Edwards 2009). Many integrations also involve struggles among key employees and high turnover rates of leadership personnel (Angwin 2004b). The capacity of managers to focus attention is limited, implying that managers concentrate on some topics while neglecting others, hampering the ability to control complex processes such as M&A integrations (Yu *et al.* 2005). Mergers and acquisition integration might therefore be the result of negotiations, compromise and collective sensemaking instead of strategic managerial decision-making; various authors have explored this perspective.

Sensemaking accounts of ongoing change might vary substantially among individuals and how individuals interpret ongoing events affects how they respond to them (Gertsen and S  derberg 2000). In collective sensemaking processes, stakeholders

engage in a discourse, which norms the views of persons or groups towards a focal topic and precedes decisions and actions (Vaara 2003). In this view, the integration process is a social construction whose outcome depends on how successful the involved stakeholders are in convincing others of their respective views (Roch 2005). Management plays an important role as a sensegiver in this process and also affects sensemaking by conducting structural interventions that employees must make sense of (Monin *et al.* 2013; Vaara and Monin 2010). Clark and Geppert (2011) termed processes of interactive sensegiving and sensemaking in integration projects 'political sensemaking'. The degree to which political sensemaking affects structural or leadership interventions and vice versa might depend on contingencies, in particular the power of the involved stakeholder groups (Clark *et al.* 2010; Monin *et al.* 2013). Vaara (2003) discussed the role of identity. If the tendency to preserve identity is strong, the target firm's management might fight intensely for its interpretation of the integration process, leading to intense struggles for meaning which affect structural and leadership interventions (cf. Drori *et al.* 2013).

A related understanding depicts the integration process as (rational) negotiations. Hubbard and Purcell (2001) identified three types of actors in integration processes: negotiators with the power to influence the integration process, enactors, typically middle managers who communicate the integration to the third group, the recipients. Merger and acquisition integration then is a process of negotiation among negotiators and one of communication among negotiators, enactors and recipients. In this view, middle management is often considered a key facilitator (or inhibitor) of the integration (Meyer 2006). The negotiation process has also been described as 'risk bartering', where negotiators trade potential or actual risks to develop a course acceptable for all involved in the process (Harwood and Chapman 2009). Confidentiality agreements might provide a protected space for those negotiations, but they isolate those not included in the agreement (Harwood 2006; Harwood and Ashleigh 2005).

Concluding this broad review of the literature, the paper now turns to an in-depth discussion of our current state of knowledge of the heterogeneous, yet related, sub-topics of M&A integration, with the aim of identifying important fields of inquiry to advance our understanding of the phenomenon.

Discussion

In the previous sections, I developed a framework that helped to summarize and structure the available literature on M&A integration, and presented a review of the integration literature arranged along this framework. In doing so, the paper advances our understanding of the phenomenon in important ways. I address the long-standing call from Schweiger and Goulet (2000) to develop an overarching framework for M&A integration research, which helps tie the various sub-topics towards a more coherent understanding of M&A integration, adding to and going beyond previous general reviews of the integration process (Schweiger and Goulet 2000; Teerikangas and Joseph 2012). This framework contributes to overcoming what Teerikangas *et al.* (2012, p.664) called the 'silo effect' in the M&A literature, the segmentation of the literature in large, widely unrelated sub-topics and perspectives. The review also provided an overview of the last decades of M&A integration research, highlighting main themes and important insights, complementing specialized M&A integration reviews (e.g. Schoenberg 2000; Stahl and Voigt 2008; Ullrich and van Dick 2007) as well as reviews on the broader field of M&A performance (e.g. King *et al.* 2004; Tuch and O'Sullivan 2007). The obtained insights now allow the development of a research agenda, structured along the integrative framework presented above.

Based on M&A integration research's roots in the decision perspective on M&As (Jemison and Sitkin 1986), our understanding of the effect of *context* variables in integration projects is well developed. In particular, we have a good understanding of the various dimensions of relatedness as well as the role employee predisposition plays for M&A integration. An important avenue for future research is to disentangle the culture construct. Reus (2012) showed that humane orientation, one dimension of national cultures in the GLOBE model (House 2004), affects how firms respond to differences in national cultures. Future research might follow up on this perspective and study other dimensions of cultural heterogeneity, addressing Teerikangas and Very's (2006, p. S31) still not fully accommodated call to develop our perspective on culture 'from yes/no to how'. Another shortcoming is the under-appreciation of macro-conditions, in particular industry, in the M&A integration literature, which is an important moderator of relationships in other fields of M&A (Pablo 1994; Schoenberg and

Reeves 1999; Teerikangas and Joseph 2012; Teerikangas *et al.* 2012). In addition, we currently do not fully understand how stakeholder power (Coff 1999; Mitchell *et al.* 1997) affects managerial agency on the top-management or middle-management level in the integration process.

The distinction between mergers (of equals) and acquisitions is also not well reflected (cf. Teerikangas and Joseph 2012). Considering that relative size (Homburg *et al.* 2009; Ranft and Lord 2002) and firm status (Hambrick and Cannella 1993; Paruchuri *et al.* 2006) are significant predictors of M&A success, both of which are related to whether a deal is an acquisition or a merger, this might be a shortcoming. Yet, distinguishing between mergers and acquisitions is difficult and various dimensions, such as potential discrepancies between deal framing and actual occurrences during the integration process need to be considered (cf. Weber and Camerer 2003).

Structural interventions have also received a lot of research attention, but gaps still exist. We now have a rich pool of knowledge regarding integration depth, aligned with various M&A integration typologies, which discuss how contextual factors and integration depth interrelate in shaping integration outcomes (e.g. Bauer and Matzler 2014; Larsson and Finkelstein 1999). The issue of integration speed has received comparatively less attention, and various questions remain unanswered. For example, we do not know whether there is a link between experience and speed. Can acquirers learn to be quick? We also know relatively little about how integration management can mitigate the downsides of high integration speed for employees' well-being and commitment (cf. Mirvis and Marks 1992). The stress literature (e.g. Crowley 2012) suggests that different interventions might increase or decrease the perceived level of stress for employees (cf. also Buono and Bowditch 1989), implying that good leadership could compensate the downsides of high integration speed (cf. Marks and Mirvis 2011).

Our knowledge regarding the operational level of integrations also requires strengthening. Some studies have examined the integration of specific firm functions, in particular IT and R&D. Alaranta and Kautz (2012), for example, showed how integration speed or experience influence IT integration (also Chang *et al.* 2014; Jordão *et al.* 2014). It is not clear, however, why IT integration should follow different patterns than other integration sub-fields such as HR integration, production integration or supply chain integration (cf. Child *et al.* 2001; Jeris *et al.* 2002).

We also know relatively little regarding how the conditions of operational integration work (e.g. integration team composition, process integration, transfer of work routines) evolve and affect integration outcomes. Scholars have just begun to open this black box (Angwin and Urs 2014; Teerikangas *et al.* 2011).

Regarding *leadership and communication-based interventions*, we have a strong idea of communication patterns between firms, as well as of the role justice and identity play. However, our knowledge of the interaction among leadership, integration characteristics and phenomena such as sensemaking is still not fully developed (cf. Teerikangas and Joseph 2012; Teerikangas *et al.* 2012). Various studies have shown how managers' sensegiving, the attempt to affect the interpretation of others regarding a specific process or event, affects integration outcomes (e.g. Monin *et al.* 2013; Searle and Ball 2004), but some open questions remain. In particular, the interaction between context and managers' ability to engage in successful sensegiving activities has not been studied thoroughly. Research is also encouraged on the creation or destruction of identity via sensemaking/sensegiving (Drori *et al.* 2013; Langley *et al.* 2012) and the role of symbolic management (Meyer 2001; Ranft and Lord 2002; cf. also Fiss and Zajac 2006) in integrations. We also need to know more about the management of relationships with external stakeholders such as customers, suppliers, the media or governmental bodies, both in terms of effects and regarding ways of managing these relationships effectively (Homburg and Bucerius 2005), in particular because the strategy literature provides abundant evidence of those relationships' importance (Bridoux and Stoelhorst 2014; Choi and Wang 2009; Henisz *et al.* 2014). Another research gap relates to leadership style. 'Heroic' leadership theories, such as neo-charismatic and transformational leadership, have been applied to the integration field (e.g. Nemanich and Vera 2009; Waldman and Javidan 2009), but those leadership theories suffer from a normative stance that has often been criticized (e.g. Crowley 2012). It would therefore be worthwhile to study more extensively how leadership develops in integration projects and what firms can do to promote effective leadership. An additional step would be to apply non-rational decision-making (e.g. Dane and Pratt 2007) and emotion and affect perspectives (e.g. Carr 2001; Delgado-Garcia and La De Fuente-Sabate 2010; Fenton-O'Creevy *et al.* 2011) to help understand leadership behaviour and leader-follower relationships (cf. Pablo 1995). Overall, the capacity

of leaders successfully to steer integrations is a somewhat under-appreciated topic (cf. Fubini *et al.* 2007; Stahl and Mendenhall 2005).

In the field of *collective sensemaking and negotiations*, some authors have demonstrated the importance of political bargaining (e.g. Clark and Geppert 2011). This perspective echoes insights from other areas of management regarding the importance of negotiation and social meaning-making for organizational behaviour (e.g. Bechky 2011; Crossland and Hambrick 2011). This perspective has found only limited application in the integration literature. For example, Suddaby and Greenwood (2005) discuss intra-organizational de-legitimation attempts, a perspective that can help reach a better understanding of integration outcomes. Future research might also examine the link between negotiated outcomes and integration context.

An under-appreciated topic is the temporality of integrations. Integrations take considerable time and the issues relevant in one stage of the integration process might not be relevant in other stages (Marks and Mirvis 2011). Management interactions that are meaningful at the beginning of an integration process could prove ineffective or even counterproductive one year in the integration. Only a few papers have accounted for this within-project dynamics so far and found evidence strengthening the notion that these dynamics matter (e.g. Meyer 2001; Monin *et al.* 2013; Rouzies and Colman 2012). Future research might consider this issue more explicitly, considering that this temporal dimension might be an important contingency condition for many of the observed relationship in M&A integration.

To sum up, it is clear that we have come a long way in understanding the phenomenon of M&A integration. However, large gaps in our knowledge still exist and much remains to be done. From my perspective, M&A integration would benefit from drawing more strongly on related literature in the broader management, organizational behaviour and strategy fields. For example, M&A integration research, despite its focus on a substantial organizational change event, has had little exchange with the broader literature on organizational change, which is both more mature and larger (for recent reviews cf. Bartunek *et al.* 2011; Maitlis and Christianson 2014; Rafferty *et al.* 2012). Recent papers have begun to bridge this gap (e.g. Cording *et al.* 2014; Monin *et al.* 2013), and it is hoped that more will follow.

Looking at the sample of studies drawn for this review, it is interesting to note the broad variety of

conceptual perspectives, but also of empirical approaches that researchers apply to study the M&A integration phenomenon. Qualitative and quantitative methodologies are applied with around the same frequency, which contrasts with the broader M&A field where quantitative approaches dominate (Cartwright *et al.* 2012; Meglio and Risberg 2011). The reason for this discrepancy is probably that the complexity of the integration process does not lend itself easily to large-scale, cross-case study designs, which are the cornerstone of the finance approach to M&As (e.g. Billett *et al.* 2004; Luo 2005). However, the strong presence of inductive approaches also indicates the still-present need for exploration and theory development in the field (Bansal and Corley 2011).

Is the plurality of methods and conceptual perspectives a strength or a weakness of M&A integration research? Considering that M&A integration as a phenomenon has highly heterogeneous aspects and that many papers on M&A integration find theoretical grounding in established theories such as sensemaking (Monin *et al.* 2013) or identification (Elstak *et al.* 2015), I believe that this heterogeneity can be regarded as a strength rather than a weakness. Still, to advance as a field, we require a conceptual understanding of how the different perspectives interrelate to develop a consistent understanding of the phenomenon (Schweiger and Goulet 2000). My intention with this paper was to help in this process.

This study has some limitations. It presented a broad review of the current state of knowledge in the M&A integration field based on journal publications presented in the last decades. This implies that I (a) did not review books and non-academic outlets, (b) did not discuss the sampled papers in full detail, (c) did not present an in-depth review of the sub-themes (such as culture or leadership) and (d) do not claim full exhaustiveness for the broad field of M&A integration. I decided instead to synthesize the overall state of knowledge into a consistent understanding of themes and their relationships and to develop a research agenda based on the obtained insights. The focus on academic journal publications results from a decision of study design and does not imply a disregard of books as outlets. Books have an important role to play, particularly regarding the transfer of academic knowledge to practitioners (Fubini *et al.* 2007; Weber 2012). It is also important to note that this paper is not meant to replace, but to complement more specialized reviews (e.g. Junni and Sarala 2014; Rottig *et al.* 2013). Future reviews on

sub-topics are welcome to flesh out the picture of the integration process.

Conclusion

Over the last 30 years, a substantive body of research on M&A integration has been developed. The current state of knowledge is extensive in some fields (e.g. regarding integration depth, organizational justice) and still developing in others (e.g. integration as negotiations, operational integration). We have empirical evidence on many context and intervention mechanisms, but it is important to consider how those interrelate. This paper has suggested a conceptual framework as one step towards the goal of synthesizing the heterogeneous knowledge on M&A integration. Developing a research agenda based on this framework, scholars particularly are encouraged to examine the interactions between sub-topics (e.g. leadership and strategy implementation) as well as to draw on the rich stock of theory and empirical insights available in related disciplines such as organizational change and organizational behaviour. Mergers and acquisitions continue to be an important phenomenon (Bauer and Matzler 2014) and developing a clear understanding of the reasons for success or failure of M&A integrations is and remains relevant.

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